



From Chatbots to Agents

Why AI is moving from answering to acting

For most people, AI still means a chat window. You type a question, the system replies, you copy the answer, and then you do the real work yourself. That was useful. It still is. But AI agents represent a more important shift: they do not just respond to a question; they can follow a goal, break it into steps, use tools, inspect information, make decisions within limits, and prepare an outcome you can review.

Think of the difference like this. A chatbot is like a helpful intern sitting beside you. It can explain GST basics, suggest a resume format, summarise a PDF, or help write a polite email.

An agent is closer to an intern with a checklist, a laptop, and controlled access to your files. It can read a document, compare it with another document, extract missing details, draft a reply, create a spreadsheet, and ask for approval before sending anything. The important words are controlled access and approval. Without them, convenience can become chaos.

An AI agent usually has five moving parts. First, it needs a goal: what exactly should be achieved? Second, it needs context: who is this for, what background matters, and what information is available? Third, it needs tools: web browsing, file reading, email, calendar, spreadsheet, code execution, image generation,